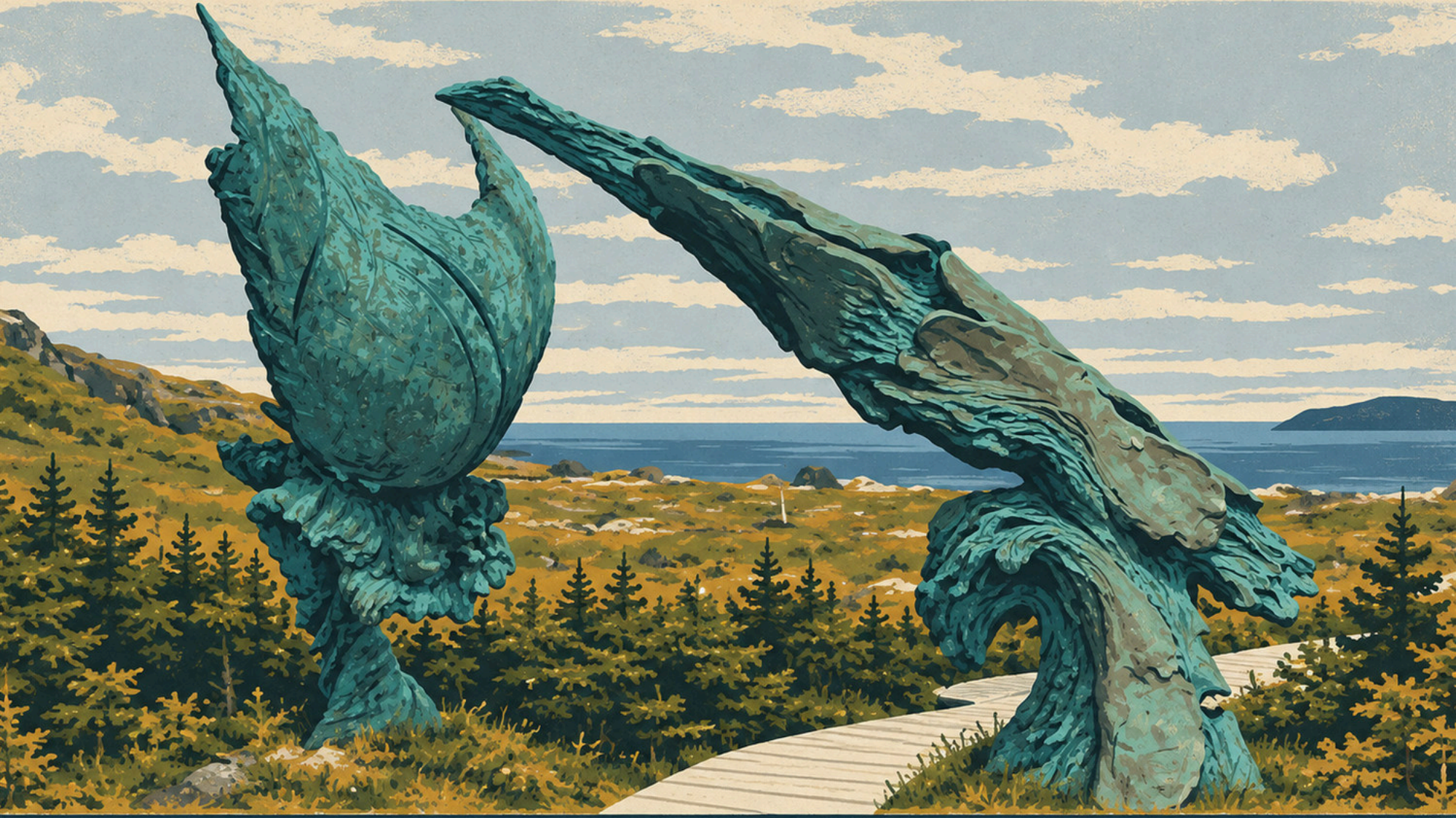


L'ANSE AUX MEADOWS

NEWFOUNDLAND AND LABRADOR

POST CARD

Hello nephew!

As you know, I spent a lot of time travelling to explore our Norse heritage. As I travelled, I collected fun stuff for you.

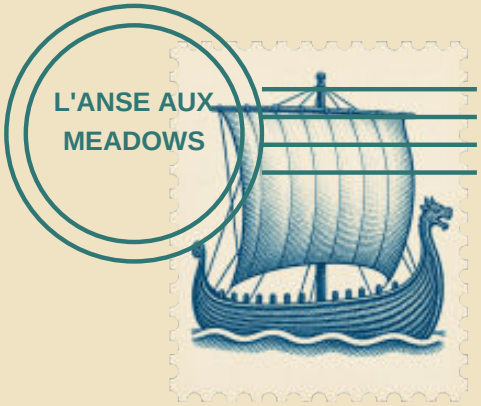
I know you love puzzles, so I created an adventure for you! With a surprise at the end!

You will explore the history of Leif Erikson, Rollo the Walker, Aud the Deep-Minded and Harald Hardrada.

This postcard comes from the first stop of my journey and should help you get started!

With love,
Aunt Liv





P.S. These postcards were never sent: they're my souvenirs, one from every stop.

FUN FACT

L'Anse aux Meadows was found after a local man pointed out odd bumps in a meadow. It is still the only confirmed Norse site in North America.

Image adaptation: "L'Anse aux Meadows, The Meeting of Two Worlds" - D. Gordon E. Robertson, CC BY-SA 3.0.



BATTLE HARBOUR

NEWFOUNDLAND AND LABRADOR

POST CARD

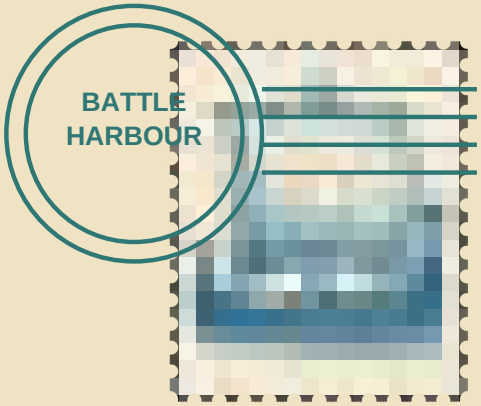
Markland today – 'Forest Land' in the old sagas, and they weren't exaggerating, it is gorgeous! Trees for miles, beautiful light and no one around!

The sky here is enormous, though somehow it always looks half finished.

Still, you'd love it here.

Love,
Aunt Liv





FUN FACT

While the Vikings never permanently settled there, they used the Labrador coast as a medieval logging camp and named it Markland — “Forest Land” in Old Norse.

Image adaptation: "Battle Harbour - MacGillivray" - Matt MacGillivray, CC BY 2.0.



BAFFIN ISLAND

NUNAVUT

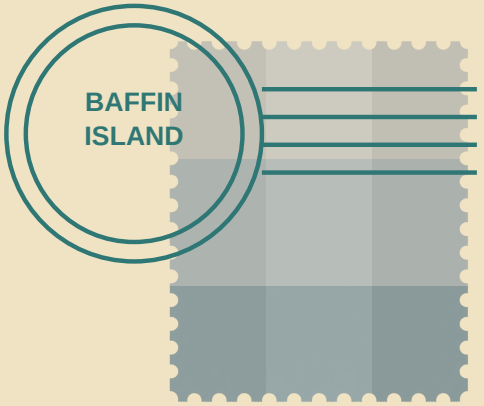
POST CARD

New stop: Helluland, "Flat Stone Land" to the sagas – and they weren't kidding about the stone either, not a tree in sight!

But last night the sky put on a show I'll never forget: green and purple curtains rippling right overhead. I stood out in the cold far too long just watching. Almost missed my supper!

Between this sky and Markland's, I think I've finally seen the whole thing.

Love,
Aunt Liv



FUN FACT

The saga says the stones here were so big that two men could lie on them heel-to-heel.

Image adaptation: "Grinnell Glacier Bergie Bits, Baffin Island" - Gregory "Slobirdr" Smith, CC BY-SA 2.0.



BRATTAHLÍÐ

GREENLAND

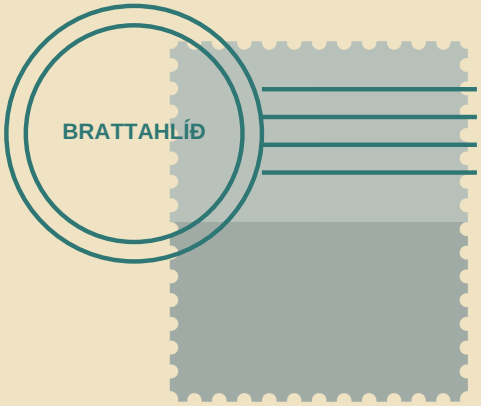
POST CARD

Amazing place today! Brattahlid, Greenland where Leif actually grew up.

It's stunning here! Erik apparently picked the name "Greenland" on purpose, to lure settlers! Funny how a name can cast a spell like that. I really enjoy those small details!

I hope you enjoy this puzzle, there might be a few steps to get the final code.

With Love,
Aunt Liv



FUN FACT

Leif's mother built Greenland's first church here. It was tiny and turf-walled, and the saga says she put it well away from pagan Erik's farmhouse.

Image adaptation: "Reproduction of Brattahlíð Viking church" - Claire Rowland, CC BY 2.0.



CHÂLUS

HAUTE-VIENNE

POST CARD

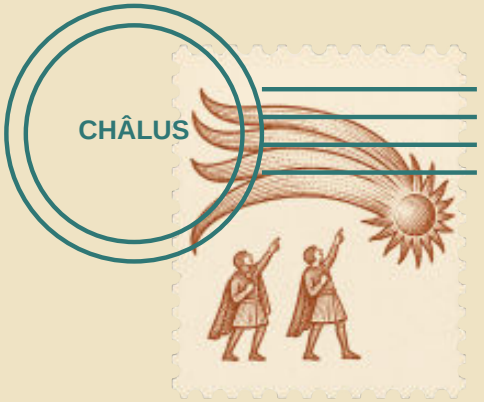
Châlus, where Richard the Lionheart's whole story ends.

He was besieging a tiny castle here over a supposed treasure hoard, of all things, when a crossbow bolt caught him in the shoulder.

Found an old carving near the gate of a bolt just like the one that got him.

With love,
Aunt Liv





FUN FACT

Richard the Lionheart (a direct descendant of Rollo) was shot here in April 1199. Legend says he pardoned the archer before he died.

Image adaptation: "Chateau Chalus Chabrol" - Fonquebure, CC BY-SA 3.0.



ROUEN

NORMANDY

POST CARD

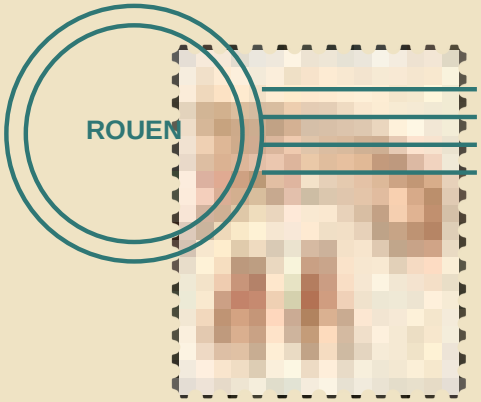
Today I got to visit Rouen, this was Rollo's own city! The King gave Rollo all of Normandy so the fighting would stop.

The city was vibrant today with lots of people milling about.

All that walking around made me crave fast-food: the battered poultry from Kentucky. Tonight's dinner was a bit fancier, the Inn I'm staying at is famous for their snails!

Maybe I should count the distances between my stops to show how many steps I took.

With love,
Aunt Liv



FUN FACT

Rouen Cathedral holds the actual heart of Richard the Lionheart, King of England and Duke of Normandy.

Image adaptation: "Rouen Place du Vieux-Marché 05" - Zairon, CC BY-SA 4.0.



BAYEUX

NORMANDY

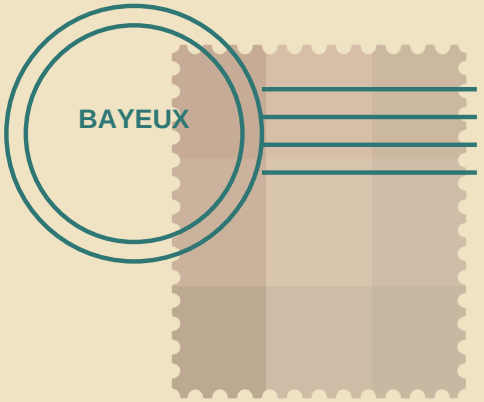
POST CARD

Today was Bayeux and its famous Norman tapestry. The tapestry was awesome! It tells the story of William the Conqueror (a direct descendant of Rollo!) taking England.

I'm obsessed with the style and you know how much I like to draw, can you find what it means?

Love,
Aunt Liv





FUN FACT

The Bayeux Tapestry shows Halley's Comet blazing over King Harold's court just before Hastings — the earliest known depiction of the comet, centuries before it got its name.

Image adaptation: Bayeux Tapestry Scene 57, photograph by Myrabella, CC0; underlying artwork public domain.



WINCHESTER

ENGLAND

POST CARD

Winchester today – freezing here, but worth every minute. This cathedral is where Richard the Lionheart was crowned a second time.

Another one of Rollo's own line! Funny to think it's all because of one deal, centuries earlier.

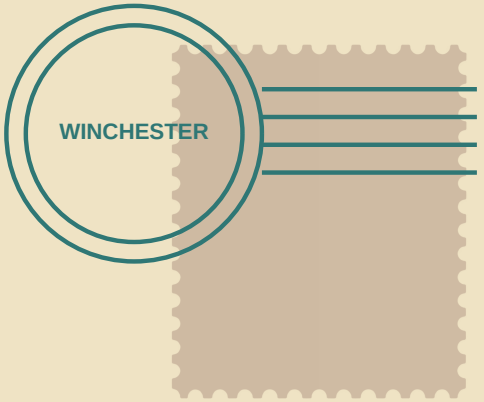
I got to enjoy the local custom of a scone and hot beverage.

Love,
Aunt Liv









FUN FACT

The Round Table hanging in Winchester's Great Hall is a genuine medieval artifact — just not King Arthur's.

Image adaptation: "Winchester cathedral - geograph.org.uk - 1628919" - Graham Horn, CC BY-SA 2.0.



BATTLE

EAST SUSSEX

POST CARD

Today I visited Battle, the village where the Battle of Hastings happened. It's so cool to be able to see it in person, especially after seeing it on the tapestry! But it doesn't really measure up to what the tapestry depicts.

I hope you're enjoying my drawings! Good thing I packed my old ruler: my maps only make sense at the right scale.

Love,
Aunt Liv





BATTLE

FUN FACT

The Bayeux Tapestry's famous scene of Harold clutching an arrow in his eye may not be original — Victorian restorers reworked stitching in that exact spot.

Image adaptation: "Sculpture at the Site of the Battle of Hastings - geograph.org.uk - 5801680" - Richard Cooke, CC BY-SA 2.0.



ROUMARE FOREST

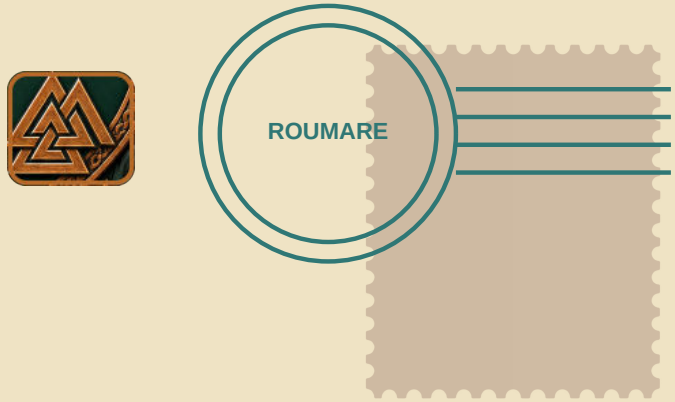
NORMANDY

POST CARD

Rollo's own Normandy, and this little forest just outside Rouen has a local legend all its own, though nobody can really pin the story down.

What I can tell you is the wild boars are real: I counted a few slipping through the beech and oak, and for every one I actually saw, I'd bet good money there was a second one just out of sight.

With love,
Aunt Liv



FUN FACT

In the year 911, the Treaty of Saint-Clair-sur-Epte handed Rollo all of Normandy, with Rouen as his new capital: the deal that turned a Viking raider into a duke.

Image adaptation: "Daguet (2)" - Nadine Toudic, CC BY-SA 4.0.



WALCHEREN

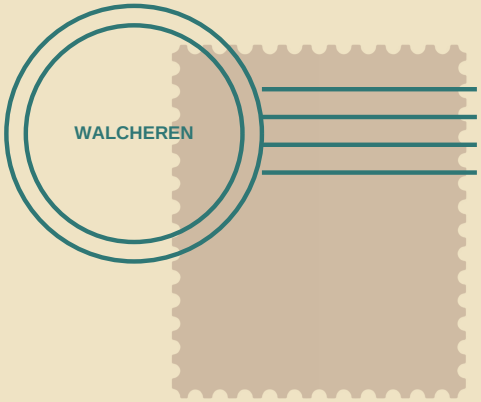
NETHERLANDS

POST CARD

Walcheren, in the Netherlands, where Vikings had already carved out their own toeholds on this coast – maybe even Rollo himself, if the old chronicles are to be believed.

Spent the evening watching the fishing boats come in with the tide and thought about him doing the exact same, centuries back.

With love,
Aunt Liv



FUN FACT

This stretch of coast saw Viking fleets wintering here for years before the year 911, when Rollo swapped raiding for a dukedom just south of here.

Image adaptation: "Walcheren, Kop van Schouwen (33)" - FrDr, CC BY-SA 4.0.



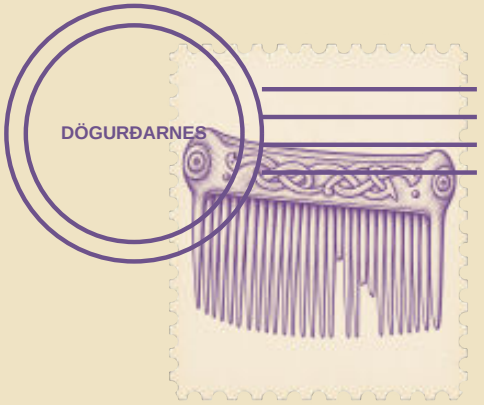
DÖGURÐARNES

ICELAND

POST CARD

Dogurdarnes today.
What a beautiful place, I understand why Aud stopped here during her journey.
I heard you can find some treasure around here, especially historical coins that fetch a pretty penny!
I was mostly interested in the coins that I got at the end of the treasure hunt.
With love,
Aunt Liv





FUN FACT

Dögurðarnes takes its name from dögurður, an Old Norse word for the day's main meal — a rest stop preserved in the map itself, long before it was a place anyone lived.

Image adaptation: sheep on lava ridge - Diego Delso, CC BY-SA 4.0.



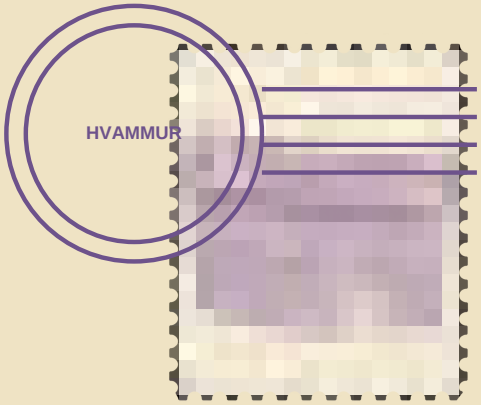
HVAMMUR

ICELAND

POST CARD

Hvammur today.
Such a lovely place and a great museum dedicated to Aud.
They even had a treasure hunt to find artifacts from Aud's time.
I was able to solve it and had a lovely time discovering the countryside. I particularly enjoyed the road that followed the forest.
It was fun to count how many bridges, fords and gates I crossed.
With love,
Aunt Liv





FUN FACT

Aud claimed the entire valley between two rivers here in Dalasysla, then freed every thrall aboard her ships and granted each one land of their own.

Sourced via Wikipedia and Guide to Iceland (see PZ-17 for links).

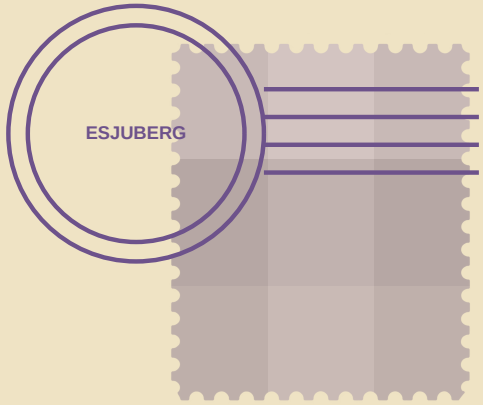


ESJUBERG

ICELAND

POST CARD

Esjuberg today.
Another beautiful place that Aud the Deep-Minded visited, my head is spinning with all the amazing landscapes!
Still amazed by the treasures I found!
With love,
Aunt Liv



FUN FACT

Esjuberg, on Kjalarnes, is where Laxdæla saga places Aud's meeting with her brother Helgi — and her refusal of his offer to settle down.

Image adaptation: Akrafjall across the bay - Diego Delso, CC BY-SA 4.0.



BJARNARHÖFN

ICELAND

POST CARD

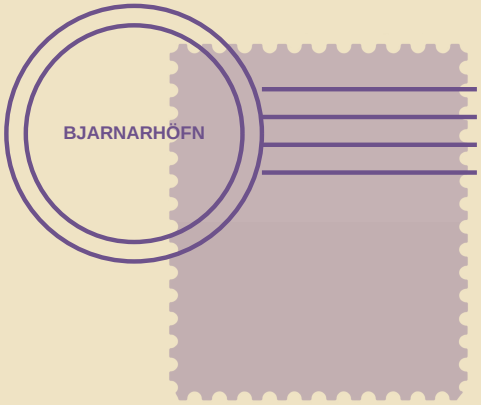
At her brother's harbor – the one Aud wintered in.

I've read everything I could find about her this trip, to the point that she feels like family (and she actually maybe was).

It was so awesome to find that comb alongside the coins, and the museum let me keep it!

This is actually the real treasure, a piece of history that we can use!

With love,
Aunt Liv



FUN FACT

Bjarnarhöfn is famous for hákarl: Greenland shark fermented, then hung to dry for months. It smells exactly as bad as it sounds.

Image adaptation: "Bjarnarhöfn Church" - David Stanley, CC BY 2.0.



OSLO

NORWAY

POST CARD

I'm spending a whole week in Oslo, so much to do!

It's Harald's city – so much Viking history.

Found the quirkiest little museum near the harbour, all about hnefatafl, the chess-like old board game the Vikings loved and that we used to play with our own rules when you were younger. Grabbed you a little souvenir from the gift shop so you can try – can you get the King to escape in exactly 3 moves? Count how far he travels each time.

Love,
Aunt Liv





FUN FACT

King Harald Hardrada established Oslo as a designated trading place. It was renamed Christiania for centuries before finally returning to the name Oslo.



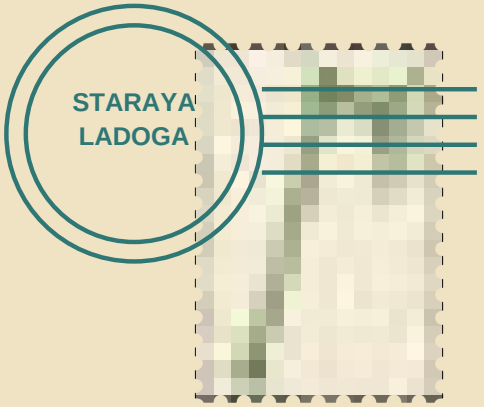
STARAYA LADOGA

RUSSIA

POST CARD

Dinners take hours here and nobody rushes, which suits me fine.
Rurik supposedly ruled from right here, if the old chronicles are true.
I climbed up on the fortress wall for a look at the whole river bend.
Nobody warned me how far this feels from anywhere else.
Keeping up with new puzzles for you is starting to be a challenge!
Love,
Aunt Liv





FUN FACT

A wooden stick carved with Viking runes was found here — probably a scrap of poetry, and one of the oldest runic finds in Russia.

Image adaptation: "The Fortress Of Staraya Ladoga. Fortress wall" - Aleksandr Baydukov, CC BY-SA 4.0.



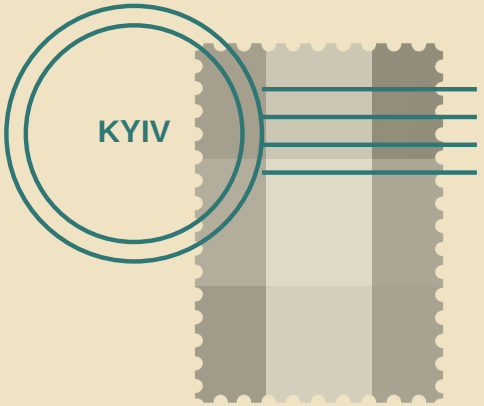
KYIV

UKRAINE

POST CARD

Kyiv, and it might be the most beautiful city on this whole trip — golden domes catching the light on every hill.
Here's a little riddle for you, the kind we used to trade back and forth: I'm sweet, but no fruit tree grew me. I'm gold, but no smith ever cast me. Thousands of tiny workers made me and set six-sided walls to guard me.
Love,
Aunt Liv





FUN FACT

Harald married Elisiv, daughter of Kyiv's Grand Prince Yaroslav, after years abroad earning a fortune to win her.

Image adaptation: "Kyiv St.Michael's Golden-Domed Monastery" - Rbrechko, CC BY-SA 4.0.



HEDEBY

GERMANY

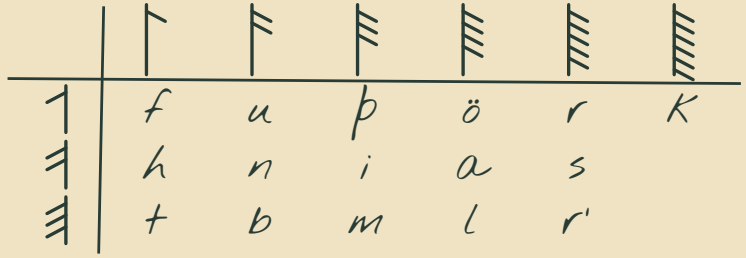
POST CARD

Today: Hedeby — barely a Hedeby left. From here I'm turning south: nothing but Mediterranean weather for the rest of this trip.

A woodcarver showed me how the old branch-runes worked — count the branches one way for the family, the other way for the letter.

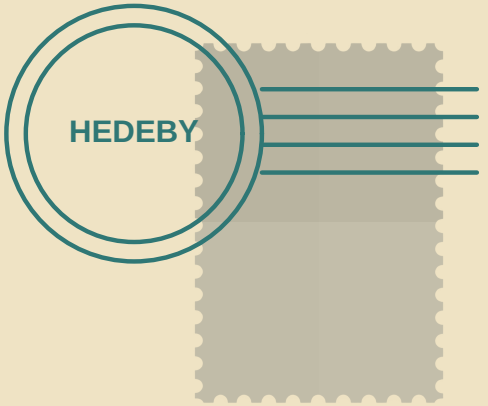
Love,
Aunt Liv

his Key, copied out:



(left branches = which row. right = where in it.)





FUN FACT

During his war with Denmark, Harald burned Hedeby to the ground — sailing burning ships straight into the harbour.

Image adaptation: "Hedeby, Busdorf (P1100664)" - Matti Blume, CC BY-SA 4.0.



SICILY

ITALY

POST CARD

Aci Castello today.

A Norman Castle in Sicily! It's crazy to think how far they travelled!

Being a good tourist, I enjoyed a gelato while walking around the ruins. Little did I know, that is a great way to attract wildlife. A RAVEN followed me the whole time! Half convinced it was you, checking up on me.

Love,
Aunt Liv



ACI
CASTELLO

FUN FACT

Aci Castello's rock is lava that cooled underwater into glassy basalt pillars. The castle sits on top of an old eruption.

Image adaptation: "Acicastello - Castello Normanno" - Pannuccis, CC BY-SA 4.0.



PATARA

TURKEY

POST CARD

Patara is the last stop of my travels for now.

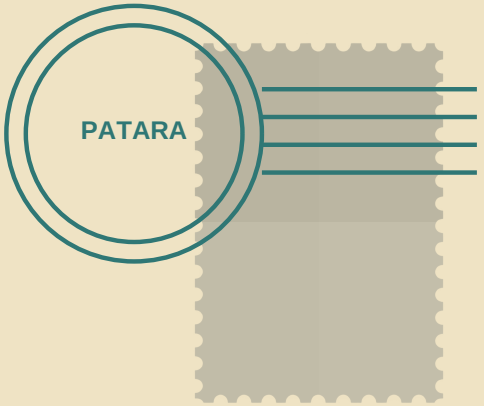
I had so much fun exploring the Vikings and Norse travels!

For your university summer break, I would love for you to join me on my next adventure. You have one more puzzle to solve and you will get your rewards!

Now you should have all you need to retrace my steps!

With love,
Aunt Liv





FUN FACT

Archaeologists discovered a Viking sword at the Patara excavation site. It almost certainly belonged to a soldier of the Varangian Guard, of which Harald was a prominent member.

Sourced via Daily Sabah, 2018 (see stops.js pataraSword).



CONSTANTINOPLE

TURKEY

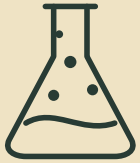
POST CARD

Constantinople – well, Istanbul now, but I like the old name for this trip.

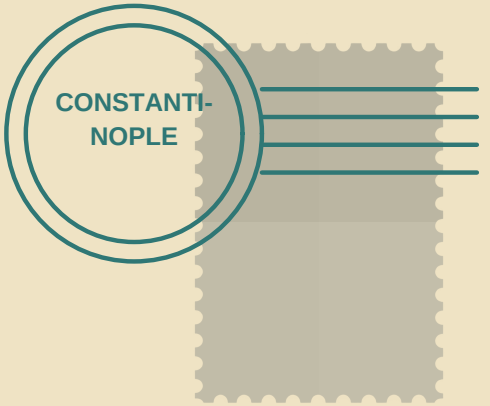
Impossible not to think about Harald everywhere here; this is where he made his fortune, long before Norway ever heard of him.

Found this in a little shop near the Hippodrome, couldn't resist.



Love,
Aunt Liv



FUN FACT

A Viking carved “Halfdan was here” in runes on a marble balustrade in Hagia Sophia. It's still there.

Image adaptation: "Historical peninsula and modern skyline of Istanbul" - Hunanuk, CC0.